

“Intersectional” Wounds in the Narratives of Humanitarian Workers and the Potential Role of Peer Support in Narrative and Symbolic Reconstruction

Research project · Conceptual note, methodology and interview guide

As part of the University Diploma in Peer Support and Neurodiversity at Université Claude Bernard Lyon 1, and of our commitment within the CoCreate Humanity association, we are conducting a qualitative study exploring the emergence of an intersectional category of wound among humanitarian workers. A singular, existential wound that finds refuge in the narrative of the self. This study also examines the role of peer support in processes of personal and collective recovery.

Name & legitimise	Co-design	Transform
Give a name and legitimacy to complex wounds that often remain unspeakable.	Design together recovery pathways that reflect who we are and respect the realities of fieldwork.	Transform our collective learning into lasting action within humanitarian organisations.

How to take part

A confidential interview of 45 to 60 minutes, in person, by phone or by video call.

Fully anonymised conversation. You may pause, postpone or withdraw at any time.

Findings are shared with all participants to continue our collective co-reflection.



Project page
cocreatehumanity.github.io/recherche

Framing the subject and the stakes

This research follows a qualitative approach in order to study the potential emergence of a singular, intersectional category of wound among humanitarian workers.

Within this work, we seek to define what we call the **intersectional wound**: this goes beyond stress or trauma. It occurs when the thread of our humanity breaks, out of a processual tension

between our values, our trust, our own identity and the sense of our commitment, all affected by the realities of fieldwork.

We are interested in how field experiences sometimes unsettle our relationship to meaning, to our deepest values and to our own personal history, and in how **peer support among humanitarian colleagues** takes part in restoring broken symbols and writing a new narrative of the self. How specifically humanitarian wounds can be named and defined will be explored through the singular narratives of participants.

This project is part of a broader effort to **destigmatise the taboos** surrounding complex wounds, by addressing, naming and accompanying them, in order to understand their real scope and to co-create community recovery mechanisms adapted and situated within the humanitarian context.

We have chosen an inductive approach grounded in **grounded theory**, whose purpose is to place the words of the people interviewed at the centre of the interaction and of the study.

Please note: this interview is not a psychological consultation. It is a peer-to-peer conversation about your trajectory and your own narrative. Your pace, your words and your fragilities are welcomed with respect, care and without judgment.

Interview guide

These questions form a general framework designed to support your narrative. They are not a closed questionnaire: you remain free to set the order, the pace, and what you wish to address or leave unsaid.

Phase 1 · Narrating the self, and rupture

- Q1.** Tell me how you came to humanitarian work, not only the professional path, but what made you stay, what gives it meaning for you.
- Q2.** Tell me about a mission or a period that marked you, not necessarily the hardest one, but the one that changed something in you.
- Q3.** If you compare the you of before and the you of today, what has changed in the way you see things, yourself, the world, humanitarian action?
- Q4.** Was there a moment when your story of yourself no longer held together, as if the pieces no longer fit?

Phase 2 · Exploring tensions and intensity

- Q5.** When you think back to that period, what comes back most: images, sensations, emotions, thoughts, dreams? And how did your body react?
- Q6.** Were there moments when you could not do what you felt was right, or when constraints such as rules, hierarchy or lack of resources clashed with what you deeply believed?
- Q7.** What was affected most deeply: trust, identity, values, your relationship to others, or something else?

Follow-up: why that rather than something else? How would you describe it in your own words?

Phase 3 · Continuum, resources and reconstruction

- Q8.** Looking at how things have evolved over recent years, what has changed in the way you carry this experience, and what remains difficult today?

Follow-up: were there turning points?

- Q9.** What allowed you to hold on, and then to find support again, at the time and over the longer term?
- Q10.** Among the different forms of help you received or had access to, did some speak to you more than others, or differently?

Follow-ups: what made that form of help different? Were there things you could say to one person and not to another?

Phase 4 · Projective questions and closing

- Q11.** If this experience were an image, a landscape or a film scene, what would it be? And if you had to describe it to someone going through something similar who has not yet found the words, what would you tell them?

Follow-ups: why that image? What would you hope they understand?

- Q12.** Is there anything important I have not asked? Would you like to add anything? How do you feel after talking about all this?

Acknowledgements

Dear humanitarian peers, your testimony is precious. This study draws on your narratives to shed light on the mental health of our colleagues and to open a reflection on cultures of support and care within humanitarian and international solidarity organisations, international and local NGOs, donors and communities of practice. We thank you for your time, your energy and your commitment to this first milestone of the research. In solidarity.

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CoCreate Humanity (CCH) is a community of humanitarian peers that provides and promotes integral, psychosocial and holistic solutions for humanitarian workers.